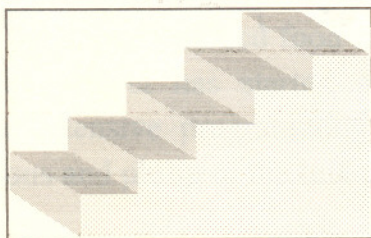


A BOON TO TRIBAL FARMERS

GIRIRAJA



A battle is on with the demon of poverty, in the region of grossly naked hill sides, barren and parching crop lands, hungry and feeble livestock; devastated socio-economy and above all weakened human population. The rampant poverty has crushed all the pillars of hope to refurbish once a region of plenty but the sons of soil have yet not surrendered to these unforeseen and uncalled for vagaries of nature. Ever since civilisation the human being occupied the centre stage and acted a lead role, he must be blamed for the current state of affairs. With the change of the act every time, s/Quarter he changed the role, given the wisdom s/he becomes the biggest commanders of the mother nature.

The act is once again on the roll, the stage is set for yet another change, the history is in making, the lessons are learnt every minute, every moment. The KRIBP project-a friend, philosopher and guide, as they treat it and refer in their naive eloquence, has shattered the stand-stillness in their attitude. The community has witnessed a new dawn amid the noon. The project has become a household provision in their daily life. Every thing they do or intend relates to the trinity of project approach *i.e.* IBUP (Integrated bottom-up planning), SHGs (Self Help Groups) and ever vigilant *Jankars* (Local Experts).

KRIBP is working in three states of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan in tribal districts of Dahod, Jhabua and Banswada respectively. The region overwhelmingly similes in agro-ecology and socio-economy. Diversified strategies of livelihoods with ever decreasing production efficiencies and low production potentials poses serious problems to sheer survival. The puzzles of vulnerability is yet to be solved and the harbingers of development have yet to pave the way in the labyrinth of poverty.

The food comes from the fields, forests and frantic migrations. The food chain is restricted to whatever is grown with the Mersey of nature and limited resources available to the families. Livestock adds to the length of food chain and gives it a

better meaning, in a sense increased nourishment, increased availability and balanced diet. This not only applies to the critical mass of human beings but to the millions of mute animals, varied flora and fauna.

Apparently a participatory farming systems approach provides the opportunity to widen the scope for enlarging the above refereed food chain without restricting its meaning. To achieve this, the project has started understanding the role of livestock in this context. The intensive programming within the ambit of the community gave new dimensions and philip to the lull system.

In March 1997 the first breakthrough achieved by introducing the Breed Improvement Program of local nondescript poultry in collaboration with Intensive Poultry Development Unit, GoG. The project arranged distribution of 250 *Rhode Island Red* birds (eighteen weeks old) strictly for breeding purpose in 19 project villages. The results enthused the community and the project to further think and act wisely. The F_1 s had fast growth rates, better feed conversion ratio, with assorted plumage colour. A fast track approach followthroughs.

♠ **Somla and Purshottam paves the way**

With the facilitation from the project two enthused farmers of village Jharola namely **Somala Kala Dangi** and **Purshottam Damor** have started their own small poultry units with 150 day old chicks of *Rhode Island Red* breed. Since then they are running this enterprise successfully with good returns rates. Looking to their success many farmers are attracted to this, considering it as Complimentary Income Generating Activity (CIGA).

Corollary to this the project started organising Animal Health and Vaccination camps with linkages of Government Animal Husbandry Department and getting success in building strong rapport between villagers and Government Animal Husbandry Department. Mass immunisation of animals against killer diseases like *Haemorrhagic Septicaemia*, *Black* and *Foot and Mouth* disease has been put on the agenda.

The trinity of project approach strike the ground producing a fountain of new and revolutionary idea to carry forward the existing program. The lessons learnt from the PRAs fed in to the search process. Several national and local institutions were contacted for the appropriate breeds of poultry suitable under the existing management system. Discussions led to decisions on both sides. The project on acquiring the information about the needs, preferences and priorities of tribal community has launched another program on poultry development recently. In November 1997 two new breeds of poultry birds have been found appropriate and brought in project villages. *Giriraja* and *Girirani* as the name suggests are most appropriate breeds for the hilly regions elsewhere in the country. The breed has

been developed by the Scientists of University of Agriculture Sciences, Bangalore and University of Agriculture Sciences, Dharwad.

Project has brought 1000 day old chicks from University of Agriculture Sciences, Bangalore on 21st November 1997 and kept them for intensive rearing in nearby private poultry farm (Lavina Poultry) Farm, Rampura for about six to eight weeks.

♠ *Giriraja and Girirani:*

The dream breeds were developed by University of Agriculture Sciences, Bangalore with crossing of improved breeds with local Indian native breeds. The breeds are having varying coloured plumage; which is foremost liking of tribal community, Hefty body size, good feed conversion capacity, fast growing and better production performance and capability to easily acclimatise in hot and humid free range scavenging habitat. Along with it male cocks are good for improving local nondescript poultry breeds by crossing of one cock to six hens.

Previously it was thought that 25 bags of feed is sufficient for 1000 day old chicks which later on became nearly double because feed conversion ratio of these birds is too high and they attains equal weight as well. After eight weeks the average weight of the birds was 2.250 kg. to 2.5 kg.

At the time of intensive rearing, exposure visits were also conducted to Lavina Poultry Farm and village Jharola. In village Jharola the objective of exposure visits are to motivate farmers for adopting small scale income generation activity by using limited resources and at Lavina Poultry Farm to expose villagers to see the performance of *Giriraja* and *Girirani* birds. In feed back sessions villagers told that six to eight weeks old birds are like five to six months old *Desi* birds they keep in their villages. these exposures also gave a chance to see and understand the intensive rearing in deep litter system. Along with exposure of village farmers training was also given to 30 poultry jankars for a period of three or more days. A number of other Institutes were also visited to Lavina Poultry farm to see the performance of *Giriraja* and *Girirani* birds. The concise detail of exposure visit and training is as shown in the Table:

After seeing these breeds demands has also came for the supply of some birds but due to lack of ample birds project has given 50 birds to Krishi Vigyan Kendra,

Jhabua. After assessing the performance of these breeds of poultry **Intensive Poultry Development Unit, Government of Gujarat** is also trying to bring *Giriraja* birds for broiler production.

S. No.	Institution	Participants		
		Male	Female	Total
1.	Project villages	299	75	374
2.	Other Institutions / NGO's	110	10	120
3.	Poultry Jankars	030	x	030
	TOTAL	439	85	524

Along with this project has also implemented **FAMPAR** trial on various poultry breeds in which five breeds viz. *Giriraja*, *Girirani*, *Kadakhnath*, *Rhode Island Red*

and local nondescript are taken for **farmer managed research trial** in village **Sarjumi**.

Now total 886 birds were distributed to the project villages, all the birds are distributed to the villages and are well adapted to local scavenging habitat. Villagers are also hoping to see these birds in their majestic body shape and size and in their maximum production.

A small beginning has given several lessons to both project and the community. The success in the subsequent months might change the scenario in near future. The project is all set to prove this initial success **“a boon to tribal farmers”**.